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BACK AT THE BARRICADE

The congressional elections that John Kennedy was so concerned about in the weeks leading up to the Cuban showdown with Khrushchev took place on November 6. Kennedy had every reason to be pleased with their outcome. The elections strengthened the Democrats' hold on the Senate, where they gained four seats. In the House of Representatives they lost one seat despite increasing the margin of their popular vote by 5 percent but retained their majority. In the gubernatorial elections neither party gained an advantage, cementing the status quo. By all accounts, it was a victory: four years earlier, in November 1959, with a Republican president in office, the Republican Party had suffered major losses on all three fronts. Now a young and inexperienced president had managed to hold his ground and even marginally improve his party's position.[1]

On Election Day, Kennedy sent Khrushchev a letter with an explicit demand to remove "the missiles and bombers, with their supporting equipment, under adequate verification, and with a proper system for